Extended Essay

To what extent have Clara Peeters' Flemish Still-LIfe paintings influenced Post-Contemporary Artists Rebecca Ruetten and Audrey Flack?

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Introduction: Clara Peeters

The post-contemporary art era marked a profound shift in the way art is created and interpreted, reflecting the shifting social, political, and cultural dynamics in society. I was intrigued by how this era allowed both traditional and newly-emerging concepts to be represented, including class systems, and how visual elements affected overall pieces. The purpose of the essay is to explore the influence of Clara Peeters' Flemish still-life paintings on post-contemporary artists Audrey Flack and Rebecca Ruetten, analyzing the extent to which Peeters' work has inspired these artists in terms of subject matter, technique, and style. By examining how Peeters' legacy has been carried forward by these contemporary artists, the essay demonstrates the continued relevance of her work and how it has inspired new generations of artists, shedding light on the enduring impact of Peeters' contributions to the field of art.

Clara Peeters, a Flemish Baroque painter born in Antwerp, Belgium in 1594, lived during a period of societal transformation and newfound wealth (Yalzadeh, 2020). Art historians recognize her as the sole female Flemish artist specializing in still-life painting during the seventeenth century, and her works remain highly sought after (Pettinau, 2016). Despite her established career, little information about her life has survived, and the absence of her name in existing records of the Antwerp painters' guild hinders a reliable chronology of her life (Life Persona Editors, 2020). Nonetheless, Peeters' still-life paintings were highly popular in her time, and several are still in private collections today (Pettinau, 2016). Her intricate and detailed paintings often depicted elaborate displays of food, drink, and luxury objects, occupying a significant place in Flemish art history. Peeters' works serve as a testament to the importance of female artists in the 17th century and showcase the unique style and skill of Flemish art (Yalzadeh, 2020).

The most remarkable aspect of her art is her desire to make an impact by including her own self-portrait in a type of artwork generally lacking in human figures as seen in her still-life paintings. Many art historians concluded it was a way for her to establish an identity as a female in the

male-dominated art world (The Courtauldian Editors, 2019). Additionally, art historians referred to her as the “forerunner of selfies” as most of her self-portraits were hidden in objects of the still lives that she painted (Life Persona Editors, 2020). Some analysis of her subjects, style, and the makers' marks on six of her surfaces and silver knives in some of her works point to her being in Antwerp. An example is found in her still-life painting entitled *Still Life with Nuts, Candy, and Flowers*, where she reflected on both the silver pot and the gold cup. These tiny depictions of herself served as an affirmation of her presence in the then-male-dominated art world (The Courtauldian Editors, 2019).

Figure 1. Peeters, Clara. Still Life with Nuts, Candy, and Flowers. 1611, Oil on Panel. 53.5 x 73 cm. Rijksmuseum, Amsterdam.



Clara Peeters' decision to paint was a radical statement, which challenged the status quo that only men are capable of creative invention. She boldly confronted her audience, demonstrating that women could be included in the art world in a place where one would least expect, such as a still-life painting of tulips and almonds. Although this may not seem like a strong statement today, Clara Peeters was a pioneer in allowing women to be seen as artists at a time when they were typically objectified (The Courtauldian Editors, 2019).

Clara Peeters' Influence on Post-Contemporary Artists

Peeters' influence on post-contemporary artists like Audrey Flack and Rebecca Ruetten can be seen in their depictions of still-life subjects and themes. For example, Flack's work often explores the role of women in consumer culture and the effects of mass media on society. Similarly, Ruetten's paintings feature detailed depictions of everyday objects, including flowers, fruits, and tableware, in a way that resembles Peeters' emphasis on material culture (Lemmey, 2022). Although both artists have not necessarily cited Peeters as a major inspiration for their work, Flack, in particular, discussed how Peeters' paintings influenced her own interest in the relationship between women and material objects, and the ways in which women are often objectified in consumer culture. Ruetten has cited Peeters' attention to detail and composition as key inspirations for her own paintings.

In Peeters painting titled, *Table with Cloth, Salt Cellar, Gilt Standing Cup, Pie, Jug, Porcelain Plate with Olives, and Cooked Fowl,* the linen tablecloth in Peeters' painting was a luxury import from the Southern Netherlands that became popular throughout Europe and was only found in affluent households. Similarly, the salt cellar was a prized object due to its high cost before industrial production methods made salt more widely available. These items were essential for preserving meats, making cheese, and preparing olives, which were considered foods for the upper class. Peeters' painting was not just a display of food, but also a representation of the opulence and

grandeur of the wealthy, as these food items were mostly unavailable to those who could not afford them (Lemmey, 2022).

Figure 2. Peeters, Clara. *Table with Cloth, Salt Cellar, Gilt Standing Cup, Pie, Jug, Porcelain Plate with Olives, and Cooked Fowl.* circa 1611. Oil on Canvas. 55 x 73 cm. Museo Nacional del Prado. Madrid.



Like other Flemish still-life paintings, Peeters' work served as a visual metaphor for the power and privilege of the wealthy and was designed to be aesthetically pleasing (Lemmey, 2022). She used a monochromatic color scheme of oranges, which was associated with wealth and luxury, to illustrate the items in the composition. By using this color scheme, Peeters created a sense of unity and harmony in her painting, and the warm shade of orange made it easier for viewers to recognize

the figures in the painting, as it provided high contrast against the black background. This contrast is a common characteristic of Flemish still-life paintings, known as chiaroscuro, which is used to create a dramatic mood and sense of depth.

Peeters utilized intricate brushstrokes to create texture and gradients, giving form to the objects in her still-life compositions. Linear perspective was used to create depth and space by arranging objects on a table that recedes into the background, forming a vanishing point. Atmospheric perspective was also employed to create the illusion of distance and depth, with objects in the background depicted with less detail, softer edges, and muted colors. The use of depth is crucial in Flemish still-life paintings, as it enhances dimension and perspective, making the painting more immersive and realistic. Peeters' use of perspective draws the viewer's eye into the composition, creating a sense of three-dimensional space and depth, and producing a convincing depiction of the objects on the table.

Furthermore, Clara Peeters' Flemish still-life paintings had a lasting impact on the art world. Her attention to detail, precision, and inventive compositions influenced generations of artists, including Audrey Flack and Rebecca Ruetten. Peeters' legacy has continued to shape the way artists approach the depiction of objects and the role of women in art. Her artistic legacy remains relevant in contemporary art, as evidenced by the use of Peeters' style, subject matter, and techniques in the work of post-contemporary artists Rebecca Ruetten and Audrey Flack.

Exploration of Audrey Flack’s Works of Art

Audrey Flack, a prominent figure in post-contemporary art and leader of the photorealist movement, explores themes related to mortality and its symbols through her mastery of color, light, and texture. Her unique and innovative style highlights the significant role of women artists during this period, and her enduring influence is evident in her highly sought-after artworks. In Flack's still-life painting, *Marilyn (Vanitas)*, two black and white portraits of Monroe are framed by a childhood

photograph of Flack and her brother (LadyKFlo Editors, 2021). The intense colors of the other objects in the scene contrast sharply with the monochrome images. An excerpt from a biography behind the photos speaks of Monroe's self-awareness and use of make-up to manipulate her image. The faded photographs, melting candles, draining hourglass, and over-ripened fruit in the painting suggest a symbolic lament to the passing of time, fading of memory, and possible loss of innocence.

Figure 3. Flack, Audrey. *Marilyn (Vanitas)*. 1977. Acrylic on canvas. 123.2 x 181.6 cm. Georgia Museum of Art, Athens.



In Flack's Vanitas series, Monroe is a prominent subject in her photorealist still-life paintings that explore themes of mortality and transience (The Art Story Editors, 2020). The series is heavily influenced by the work of Peeters as Flack combines a range of objects in *Marilyn (Vanitas)* to create

a complex still-life arrangement that references both Peeters' work and contemporary pop culture. The use of the skull in the painting is a clear reference to Peeters' work, which often included symbols of mortality and transience. Similarly, Flack's use of cosmetics and the mirror reflect Peeters' interest in using objects to convey deeper meanings about beauty and vanity. The burning candle found in Flack's painting represents Marilyn's passionate fans as well as her wild love life, while also symbolizing the slow-burning of time that eventually runs out. Flack also includes James Dean in the painting's reflection, similar to Peeters' practice of adding hidden details in her still-life paintings.

Flack's painting portrays the symbolism of mortality and the ephemeral nature of life. It celebrates the textures and colors of realism with depictions of hyper realistic objects. The painting commemorates the life and death of Marilyn Monroe, portraying her at 22 years old and at 36 years old when she died (The Art Story Editors, 2020). Flack's inclusion of Monroe in the painting departs from Peeters' work, which usually featured only inanimate objects. Flack incorporates elements of contemporary pop culture into her still-life arrangements from a feminist perspective. The painting highlights the transience of beauty and how women's bodies are objectified and commodified in modern society. The photorealism in the painting creates a contrast between Monroe's idealized image and the harsh reality of her mortality (LadyKFlo Editors, 2021).

Clara Peeters' Influence on Audrey Flack's Work

Flack's work shares many similarities with Peeters' paintings. Like Peeters, Flack often depicts still-life arrangements that are highly detailed and carefully composed. Her paintings often feature a range of objects, from musical instruments and books to jewelry and cosmetics, which are arranged in a way that suggests a deeper narrative. Flack's use of symbolism is also reminiscent of Peeters' work. For example, in her painting *Wheel of Fortune*, Flack depicts a range of objects, including a skull, a clock, and a tarot card, which suggest themes of mortality, time, and fate. Similarly, Peeters

often included objects in her paintings that symbolized the transience of life, such as wilting flowers or rotting fruit.

Figure 4. Flack, Audrey. *Wheel of Fortune (Vanitas)*. 1977. Acrylic on Canvas. 119.4 x 88.9 cm. National Gallery of Art, Washington, D.C.



However, while Flack's work clearly reflects Peeters' influence, she has also pushed the boundaries of the still-life genre in her own way. For example, her painting *Marilyn* features a complex arrangement of objects, including a photograph of Marilyn Monroe, a bouquet of flowers, and a vase of cigarette butts, which suggest themes of femininity, consumerism, and mortality. This combination of disparate objects and themes is characteristic of Flack's work, which often challenges traditional ideas about beauty, gender, and identity (LadyKFlo Editors, 2021).

Flack's *Marilyn (Vanitas)* demonstrates Peeters' influence in its use of symbols of mortality and transience, as well as its focus on objects related to beauty and vanity. However, Flack's inclusion of Monroe reflects her broader interest in incorporating elements of contemporary pop culture into her work and her feminist perspective. Flack has built upon Peeters' legacy by incorporating elements of contemporary pop culture and feminism into the still-life genre, while Peeters is known for her meticulously detailed paintings of fruits, flowers, and other objects, Flack's work expands the genre to include a wider range of objects and themes.

Flack's painting is a modern take on 17th-century Flemish still-life paintings that were specifically inspired by the vanitas tradition (LadyKFlo Editors, 2021). As Flemish still-life had its main purpose to understand the transient nature of time, Flack's painting portrays a number of different watches, fruits, flowers, and lit candles, all objects that are quick to become obsolete, to relay the swift message of mortal time (Maurer, 2009). Flack was able to model Flemish still-life by having meaning to each object. For example, the watch and hourglass on the right side of the painting represent time stopping as art such as paintings don't move, this is meant to represent the transient nature of time, and Marilyn's death as her time stopped early and forever, she is frozen in time, just like Flack's painting.

Flack's use of photorealism contrasts Monroe's idealized image with the harsh reality of mortality, highlighting how women's bodies are objectified and commodified in contemporary society. Flack's attention to detail and use of symbols like Peeters suggest themes of mortality, transience, and the fleeting nature of beauty (Maurer, 2009).

Exploration of Rebecca Ruetten's Works of Art

Ruetten uses her photography to both aestheticize and criticize American fast food culture to further shed light on the contemporary issues of class and financial status (Bahadur, 2017). Reutten begins by noting that the sculptures are *contemporary pieces*, which implies that they are modern

works of art. She then describes each piece in detail, providing readers with a vivid mental image of them. Likewise to Flemish still-life, she also focuses on everyday objects and their symbolic meanings in these paintings have also been used by Rütten to explore the significance of everyday objects in her sculptures. “To eat healthy is expensive,” Ruetten explains, “However, one can buy large amounts of food at a fast food restaurant for a comparatively low price”. She defines fast food to be genetically modified foods that are solely designed for mass consumption. She mentions how “food becomes a non-edible object and loses its value as being considered Food” (Bahadur, 2017).

Figure 5. Ruetten, Rebecca. *Contemporary Pieces*. 2013. Photography. Unspecified.



Ruetten's photography features a dark interior scene with a triad color scheme of orange, green, and violet. Oranges appear as pops of color on the nachos and tacos, reminiscent of the

precise detail found in Flemish still-life paintings. Ruetten's sculpture pieces adopt this color scheme as well. A triadic split-complementary color scheme is common in Flemish still-life paintings, but post-contemporary artists tend to use brighter and more vibrant tints of orange. The color and lighting in Ruetten's photograph create high contrast and emphasize the saturation and tones of the warmer shades of orange. The preference for bolder and more vibrant works of art is a departure from the muted colors of Flemish still-life paintings. This change in preference is due to the Pop Art movement, characterized by its bright colors and prominent pigments (Custodio, 2020). Triadic split-complementary colors, such as primary colors of red, yellow, blue, and secondary colors of orange, green, and violet, also increased in popularity.

Clara Peeters' Influence on Rebecca Ruetten's Work

While it is unclear whether Ruetten was directly influenced by Peeters, there are certainly similarities between their work. Both artists create highly stylized still-life images that emphasize the beauty and richness of their subjects. In particular, both artists are interested in the symbolism of food and other luxury items, and use these objects to explore themes of desire, excess, and consumerism.

One possible source of influence for Ruetten could be the wider tradition of still life painting, of which Clara Peeters is a part. Ruetten's photographs share many similarities with the still-life paintings of other artists from the Baroque period and beyond. For example, both Ruetten and Peeters use lighting and composition to create a sense of depth and texture in their images, and both artists are interested in the intricate details and textures of their subjects. Although there is no direct evidence of Peeters' influence on Ruetten's photography, it is clear that both artists are part of a long tradition of still-life art that values beauty, detail, and symbolism. As such, it is likely that Ruetten has been influenced by the wider still life tradition, of which Peeters is an important figure.

Figure 6. Ruetten, Rebecca. Contemporary Pieces. 2013. Photography. Unspecified. Made in https://color.adobe.com/create/image.



Additionally, the photography series reflects Peeters' still-life painting influence in its attention to detail and texture. Peeters was known for her highly detailed and realistic still-life paintings, which often featured a range of textures, from the shiny surface of a glass goblet to the rough, bumpy skin of a piece of fruit. Similarly, Ruetten's *Contemporary Pieces* series features objects that are rendered with an incredible level of detail, highlighting the intricate textures and surfaces of each object. Moreover, Ruetten's series reflects Peeters' influence in its use of symbolism. Peeters' still life paintings often included symbolic elements, such as a skull or a wilting flower, which suggested themes of mortality and transience. Similarly, Ruetten's *Contemporary Pieces* series includes objects that are rich in symbolic meaning, such as a handbag or a pair of high heels, which suggest themes of consumerism, desire, and femininity.

Ruetten utilized techniques commonly found in Flemish still-life painting to create her photograph. The color black dominates the background, with a single light source illuminating the objects on the left side. Tenebrism, a style popularized during the Baroque period, was used to create a dramatic effect by emphasizing the contrast between the light and dark areas of the photo. Chiaroscuro, another technique commonly used in Flemish still-life paintings, was also utilized to create depth and atmosphere in the photograph. By using these techniques, Ruetten was able to draw attention to the main subject of the photo, the taco bell food, and create a dramatic and intense effect. The black background was also used to increase the illusion of three-dimensional space and enhance the emphasis on the main subject.

Ruetten's compositions share similarities with Peeters' paintings in their use of light and shadow. Peeters was known for her dramatic use of light to create a sense of depth and dimensionality in her still-life paintings. Similarly, Ruetten's photographs often feature dramatic lighting, with objects cast in deep shadows or illuminated by a single source of light. This use of lighting helps to create a sense of depth and texture in the images, making the objects seem almost three-dimensional.

Peeters and Ruetten use their still-life compositions to explore themes of desire and consumerism. Peeters often includes luxurious items such as silverware, exotic fruits, and expensive fabrics in her paintings to symbolize wealth and status. Ruetten's photographs also often showcase luxury goods like designer handbags, shoes, and jewelry that are arranged to highlight their desirability and beauty. Both artists investigate the relationship between people and objects in their work. Peeters' paintings frequently depict objects arranged in a way that implies human interaction, such as partially eaten fruit or a peeled lemon. Similarly, Ruetten's photographs often feature suggestive arrangements of objects, such as a pair of shoes positioned as if waiting for someone to step into them. These arrangements suggest a human presence, even if no one is visible in the image.

While Rebecca Ruetten's *Contemporary Pieces* series is not directly inspired by Clara Peeters' still-life paintings, it reflects many of the same themes and techniques that Peeters used in her work. Both artists are interested in exploring the relationship between people and objects, and in using highly stylized compositions and intricate details to create a sense of richness and symbolism in their work.

Analysis of Peeters' influence on Ruetten and Flack

Peeters' influence on Flack's *Marilyn (Vanitas)* and Ruetten's photography series *Contemporary Pieces* can be compared and contrasted in several ways. Both Flack and Ruetten explore the themes of vanity and mortality in Peeters' still-life paintings. However, the two artists differ in their approach to composition and style. Flack's painting is a photorealistic rendering of her still-life composition, while Ruetten's photographs are highly stylized and use lighting, color, and composition to create a sense of drama and impact. Another difference between the two artworks is the use of symbolism. While Peeters often used symbolic elements such as skulls or wilting flowers in her paintings to suggest themes of mortality and transience, Flack and Ruetten use a range of objects that are rich in symbolism.

While both Audrey Flack's painting *Marilyn (Vanitas)* and Rebecca Ruetten's photography series *Contemporary Pieces* are influenced by Clara Peeters' still-life paintings, they differ in their approaches to composition, style, and symbolism. Flack's painting is a photorealistic rendering of a still-life composition that explores themes of mortality and vanity, while Ruetten's photographs use dramatic lighting, color, and composition to create a stylized interpretation of the still-life genre that explores themes of desire and consumerism.

Audrey Flack and Ruetten have interpreted Peeters' influence in their own unique ways, showcasing individual approaches to art. Flack's interpretation extends beyond traditional still-life painting, incorporating elements of popular culture and femininity. By including Marilyn Monroe's

image and using makeup and pearls, Flack adds a pop-culture element and suggests themes of beauty. Conversely, Ruetten's *Contemporary Pieces* series emphasizes drama and impact through stylized photography, lighting, color, and composition, creating a highly impactful and stylized interpretation of the still-life genre.

These differences in Flack and Ruetten's interpretations of Peeters' influence demonstrate their individual approaches to art. Flack's approach emphasizes realism and texture while incorporating elements of popular culture and femininity into her work. In contrast, Ruetten's approach emphasizes stylization and dramatic impact while exploring contemporary themes of consumerism and desire. By interpreting Peeters' influence in their own way, Flack and Ruetten demonstrate their individuality as post-contemporary artists and showcase the continued relevance and versatility of the still-life genre.

Both Audrey Flack's *Marilyn* and Ruetten's *Contemporary Pieces* explore themes of mortality and transience influenced by Peeters' still-life paintings, but they differ in how Peeters' influence is expressed. Flack's work is a photorealistic still-life painting that includes a pop-culture element and emphasizes femininity and beauty through the use of makeup and pearls. In contrast, Ruetten's *Contemporary Pieces* are stylized photographs that use dramatic lighting, color, and composition to create a sense of impact and tension. While both artworks explore mortality and transience, there are differences in how Peeters' influence is manifested in the works. The medium is one difference, as Flack's work is a painting and Ruetten's is a photograph. Composition and style are also different, with Flack's painting carefully arranged for realism and texture, and Ruetten's photographs featuring a range of objects arranged to create drama. Additionally, Flack's work centers around a symbol of mortality, while Ruetten's often includes objects alluding to human presence.

Conclusion

Through a comparative analysis of Peeters', Ruetten's and Flack's paintings, the essay demonstrates the continuing relevance of Peeters' work and the impact of her artistic legacy on contemporary art. Additionally, the influence of Clara Peeters' Flemish still-life paintings on post-contemporary artists Rebecca Ruetten and Audrey Flack is evident through their utilization of Peeters' distinctive style, subject matter, and techniques, ultimately highlighting the continued relevance and impact of Peeters' artistic legacy in the contemporary art world.

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